of Indian-Soviet relations. The worse the relations are between India and China the more need India feels for close Soviet backing."[54] For this reason, Kissinger did indeed tell Chinese officials that India was "loosen[ing]" its relations with the Soviet Union, and that Delhi was not coordinating its policies with Moscow as closely as before.[55]

On the other hand, the US found it convenient to use that same India-Soviet relationship to emphasize to Chinese officials that Sino-US ties were crucial. Moreover, Kissinger was concerned about how Beijing, which remained suspicious of Washington's intentions, would view American officials urging them to reconcile with India. Promoting "better Sino-Indian relations in a way that makes the Chinese nervous" was not in American interest. He instructed Ambassador-Designate to India William Saxbe to avoid the issue publicly, but, if prompted by Indian officials, to "say that we have absolutely no objection to an improvement."[56] Kissinger also did not directly urge Chinese officials to patch things up with India. He did, however, mention to them that Delhi had asked Washington to let Beijing know about their intentions, adding that he was sure that China and India could use their direct channels to communicate.[57]

American officials also advised Indian officials that deepening relations with the Soviet Union would increase Chinese distrust of India and make normalization less likely. Foreign Minister Yashwantrao Balwantrao (Y. B.) Chavan, however, told Kissinger, "The Chinese view of India as a Soviet appendage is wrong." And Kaul asked why Beijing "[did] not try to wean us away from the Soviets." US officials believed that China, however, saw "aloofness" rather than rapprochement as a way to keep the India-Soviet tie from becoming even closer.[58] The Chinese attitude seemed to serve that purpose to an extent. Indian concern about the Chinese reaction was one reason that Delhi continued to stay away from any Soviet collective security plans. Indian officials demurred when Brezhnev again suggested in August 1973 that the Indo-Soviet treaty was part of the initial stage toward a collective security system. The government then refused to endorse related Soviet proposals when Brezhnev visited India in November 1973. During Brezhnev's visit Gandhi furthermore publicly reiterated that India-Soviet "friendship is not aimed at any other country. There is no reason for our friendship with the USSR to exclude friendship with other countries.… We too wish to expand the area of our friendship." Subsequently, India